

JOINT STATEMENT FOLLOWING THE INAUGURAL MEETING ON SEPTEMBER 15 2021 OF
:

THE CENTER FOR INTERRELIGIOUS AND INTERCULTURAL DIALOGUE IN IRAN WITH
THE AUSTRALIAN CENTRE FOR CHRISTIANITY AND CULTURE AND THE NATIONAL
COUNCIL OF CHURCHES OF AUSTRALIA.

The evidence is clear~~vivid~~ that healthier relations between members of the one human family
are now crucial.

Adversarial~~-, unforgiving-,~~ habitually conflictual relations between nations and cultures are
destroying the planet and causing immense and~~-,~~ tragic ~~-suffering-~~.

People of faith have a vital~~unique~~ ~~-~~opportunity ~~-~~and special responsibility to help humankind
cultivate a planetary life that is more loving~~-,~~ more understanding and more ~~-~~forgiving.

These were the common views of all participants ~~were amongst agreed perceptions shared~~ at
the first meeting of the leaders of both the Iranian Center for Interreligious and Intercultural
Dialogue(CID) and the Australian Centre for Christianity and Culture(ACC&C),with the National
Council of Churches of Australia(NCCA).

This first ~~-~~virtual meeting took place on Wednesday September 15.

Our new connection was greatly assisted by the Embassy of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

While both of us have established Dialogues and Partnerships with other international Centres,
for each of us this is a new ~~-~~venture~~-,~~ linking Iran and Australia~~-~~.

We shared our delight that this link has become possible and expressed our mutual sense of
responsibility to make the best of our connection.

Our common concern was expressed as a question: ~~Hence we asked each other-,~~ how can we
better serve humanity together?

Looking ahead to future meetings~~-,~~ we asked what can people of faith in Iran and in Australia
do together regarding climate change and the plight of people displaced as refugees?

Whilst these issues were agreed as forming an agenda for a next Webinar~~-,~~ this agreement
came after sharing some aspects ~~-~~of our personal stories .

We found common experiences~~-,~~ notwithstanding the distance between Iran and Australia:

These included our family backgrounds in rural and regional areas; the impact of war's trauma on our respective families and our many years of adult life in multifaith and multicultural settings.

Agreeing to focus next on climate change and on the plight of refugees, we were assisted by our consideration of the September "***Joint Message for the Protection of Creation***" ~~recently made public~~ by the Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew, Pope Francis and the Archbishop of Canterbury.

~~We are a~~Aware of equivalent Statements made by Islamic leaders, and conscious of the crucial upcoming climate change conference, UN COP 26, which begins on October 31 in Glasgow. ~~We, we agreed to to each offer our prayers from the beginning until the end of the conference, from its beginning until its end.~~

~~We agreed to offer our prayers,~~ along with other people of faith, including on the virtual platforms that may be available internationally during COP26.

Our initial meeting concluded with much warmth. We now hold each other in the prayers of our hearts as our important Dialogue evolves.

We pray for each other and for our future work with the understanding that the earth is our common home and that we share a responsibility to look after each child of the planet.

BISHOP PHILIP HUGGINS